



THEY SEE A FREE INDIVIDUAL, IT'S GONNA SCARE 'EM

EASY RIDER / 1969

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Road movie

DIRECTOR
Dennis Hopper

WRITERS
Peter Fonda, Dennis Hopper, Terry Southern

STARS
Peter Fonda, Dennis Hopper, Jack Nicholson

BEFORE
1953 *The Wild One*, in which Marlon Brando smolders as a motorcycle gang leader, was the first movie to focus on the idea of outlaw bikers.

1960 Jean-Luc Godard's *À bout de souffle* prefigures *Easy Rider* with its couple of young outlaws on the road, and jump-cut editing.

AFTER
1976 *Easy Rider* inspires a number of road movies, significant among them Wim Wenders' *Kings of the Road*.

Few movies seem to capture a moment in time more completely than Dennis Hopper and Peter Fonda's *Easy Rider*. It's the quintessential American road movie, with two youngish men, half hippy, half Hells Angels, setting off on a journey to freedom on their Harley-Davidson motorcycles.

End of the 1960s

There's no real plot or emotional journey, and the movie's vague symbolism may seem dated now. But there's no denying its cultural status at the time. The year it was released, 1969, young people were proclaiming their rejection of the values of the old generation by growing their hair long and dropping out to listen to music and take drugs. *Easy Rider* reflected this mood, but it went further.

Peter Fonda, the producer and star, came to the project from playing the rebellious leader of a gang of Hells Angels in the movie *The Wild Angels* (1966), and a TV ad director who takes LSD in *The Trip* (1967). Both movies were



Easy Rider helped to spark the New Hollywood phase of filmmaking in the early 1970s, in which directors took a more authorial role, and innovative publicity techniques were used.

big commercial successes with the younger generation. It seemed only natural to combine the two themes, biker gangs and drugs, in one movie.

Fonda brought in screenwriter Terry Southern to help with the writing and hired Dennis Hopper as his co-star and director. Hopper may at first have seemed like a disastrous choice as director, as the shoot threatened to

